Part 5 — Venkata Josyula — STAR answer bank (product + behavioral, bar-raiser style)

Friday Oct 30, 12:00 PM PDT · Principal PM, FBA · the last interview of the loop · Amazon L6 Senior Supply Chain Manager, NACF

Rajesh Rishiyur Chandrasekaran · every answer is STAR, first person, with the number to land, what not to say, the source story and the likely follow-up. Product / customer angle only — Rocky got program and cutover, James got process and governance.

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A · How to run this hour (cram) and the ten stories, three levels deep
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A · How to run this hour

Who he is. Principal PM in FBA, so he thinks about the seller as a customer, inbound trust, and mechanisms that scale. He is the bar raiser, so he will dig three levels into one story, separate *I* from *we*, and ask what failed. **My frame for him:** "I treat supply-chain programs as products: a named customer, a written problem, a ranked requirement list with a visible deferral list, a metric chosen before launch, and a gate held in public."

THREE OPENING SENTENCES (PICK ONE WHEN HE SAYS "TELL ME ABOUT YOURSELF")

- "I build the systems that decide what we can promise a customer — order allocation at Manhattan, visibility at Flexport, inventory and warehouse programs at Sephora — and I run them like products: customer, metric, gate."
- "The pattern in my work is that the customer was being promised from the wrong place, and my job was to make one true promise and prove it with a number we agreed before launch."
- "I am happiest when the deferral list is written down, the launch gate is published before the wave, and the review makes the decision instead of me."

THE FIVE NUMBERS NEVER TO GET WRONG

- **Shipment Visibility:** 7 to 68 customers, 9.7 times; cost to serve $0.66 to $0.03 per container, about 95%. Never round to ten times. record
- **Manhattan discrepancy:** about 200 orders, $2.5M of *order value*; the $10M is the *initiative won*, not savings. record
- **Snowflake pipeline:** four systems to one; WBR accuracy 60% to 90%; the status quo was *priced* at over $100K a year, not saved. record
- **EDI lanes:** a thousand lanes were asked; 597 carrying 80% of spend went first; completeness 60% to 95%. record
- **LLM triage:** $25 to $0.40 per incident, 98%, independent build — not an employer deployment. record

Freshness. The hiring manager heard Shipment Visibility from the operating lens and the Flexport FF App roadmap / cost-to-serve story; Ryan was routed through S9 among others. With Venkata, Shipment Visibility is told as a *product* (graduation criteria, the customer it protected, the flattering number thrown away), S12 only as the rebuild-or-reuse rule and partner adoption, and S9 only as the customer conversation and the small-carrier floor. If he says "I think you told

> my colleague this," say: "You may have heard the program; I'll give you the product decision inside it, which they didn't get."

The ten stories — the 20-second version, the trade-off, the failure line, three levels deep

Use each card when he digs. Level 1 is what I did; level 2 is how I knew; level 3 is what I would change or what proves it. Basis labels: **record** = Apple v11 / resume / master packet; **record-from-docs** = a page of a program document.

V1 · S11 — Flexport Shipment Visibility as a product: 7 → 68 customers behind six published graduation criteria

LPs Customer Obsession · Deliver Results · Earn Trust · Insist on the Highest Standards

20-second version. Leadership told me the visibility program was not showing value. I was program owner across nine teams and about a hundred people. I published six graduation criteria to Sales before wave one, held wave three in public on an ETA-accuracy miss from one bad source, and threw away a flattering 99.4% week. We went from 7 to 68 customers with zero rollbacks, and cost to serve fell from $0.66 to $0.03 per container.

TRADE-OFF I MADE. Sales wanted the whole pool boarded at once. I chose waves behind criteria, which cost us speed in the first two quarters; the VP still unlocked the 68-customer rollout two months early.

Failure / learning. I started the weekly review after the critique, not at kickoff. Next time the review starts on day one.

Three levels deep. L1: I wrote the seven metric definitions and the six graduation criteria. L2: the owner of each input — Data Services, Support, GTM — signed the definition they would be red against; a 300-container sample gave ±1.6% at 95% confidence. L3: what proves it held is that the customers we held in wave three became the cleanest wave.

SAFE-SAY. "Seven to sixty-eight customers is 9.7 times, and cost to serve per container went from sixty-six cents to three cents — about ninety-five percent." **Source?** "The State of SV and pilot roll-out documents, and the master packet's launch record."

V2 · Crux customer transition — 79 customers, a segment rule each, honest cancels

LPs Customer Obsession · Earn Trust · Are Right, A Lot · Have Backbone

20-second version. Flexport had acquired a visibility product, Crux, with 79 customers — $185,892 of ARR and 294,581 containers in 2021 — and the aim was to move them to Shipment Visibility by end 2022. Not every segment fit. The decision gave each segment a rule: shippers to Shipment Visibility, forwarders, customs brokers and 3PLs to the SV API with no extra dev, two brokers to a partner product, and the two competitor SaaS accounts cancelled on published dates.

TRADE-OFF I MADE. Building parity features for small segments versus a clean path or a clean cancel. The decision chose no extra build; the cost was some revenue and some goodwill in the long tail.

Failure / learning. The dissent in the document asked for the cost of keeping Crux running; that number should have been in the first draft, not requested by a reviewer.

Three levels deep. L1: the segment table — GKA 2, Enterprise 14, SMB 39 to SV. L2: the two brokers carried most of the volume, so they got individual calls; one relationship mattered because of a 600-truck drayage partner. L3: cancels dated August 1 and October 24, 2022 are the proof that the hard part was done, not deferred.

SAFE-SAY. "Seventy-nine customers, about $186 thousand of ARR — I do not claim any preserved-ARR number, because the document doesn't have one." **Source?** "The RAPID decision document for the Crux customer transition, the 2022 version."

V3 · S14 — Manhattan: the $2.5M OMS↔WMS discrepancy my manager wanted fixed quietly

LPs Earn Trust · Have Backbone · Customer Obsession · Bias for Action

20-second version. Two days before an executive review, OMS and WMS did not reconcile — about 200 orders, $2.5M of order value — and a $10M initiative rode on the review. My manager and the room favored a quiet back-end fix. I built the discrepancy census by cause, argued risk not virtue, offered to run the war room myself, and we told the customer first. The prioritized orders were patched line by line, and the initiative was won.

TRADE-OFF I MADE. Quiet script versus transparency. I chose transparency and put the cost — my time in a war room, my risk of being wrong in front of the customer — on myself.

Failure / learning. I should have proposed the standing reconciliation report before there was a crisis to justify it.

Three levels deep. L1: the census by cause and the options memo were mine; the consultants traced the handshake and wrote the patch. L2: a cross-table script written in two days had no rollback; per-line patching did. L3: the standing reason-coded reconciliation report, read before every executive review, is what outlived the war room.

SAFE-SAY. “The $2.5 million is order value in discrepancy; the $10 million is the initiative the customer awarded — I don't count it as savings.” **Source?** “My Manhattan consulting record, as captured in the master packet.”

V4 · S16 — Flexport: four systems into one Snowflake pipeline

LPs Ownership · Invent and Simplify · Frugality · Learn and Be Curious

20-second version. Our Monday review ran on four systems stitched together in Google Sheets by one person — me. Accuracy was 60%, tickets had no container ID, and a VP was steering on a number I could break. I wrote the BRD, priced the status quo at over $100K a year in the infra team's own rates, and held cutover to a parallel run within 1% for consecutive weeks. Accuracy went to 90%, and the first automated catch was a 4% ticket-sync drop nobody could see before.

TRADE-OFF I MADE. Build the pipeline before or after the rollout. I kept the manual pull running every Monday as the rollback rather than pause the review.

Failure / learning. I did not plan the data-access security review and it cost two weeks; I owned it upward the same day. (That miss is James's failure story — mention it in one line only.)

Three levels deep. L1: I wrote the BRD and owned cutover; infra built it. L2: the join gap — tickets without a container ID — was solved with a cross-reference table first, then a real key pushed upstream. L3: bus factor went from one to at least two, and the definitions now live in code.

SAFE-SAY. “The hundred thousand is a priced baseline in the infra team's own rates — it is not a savings claim.” **Source?** “The BRD for SV Zendesk data in Snowflake and the master packet's S16 record.”

V5 · S9 — Elementum: a thousand lanes asked, 597 built first

LPs Have Backbone · Customer Obsession · Insist on the Highest Standards · Success and Scale

20-second version. The customer's Global Head of Supply Chain wanted inbound visibility on a thousand lanes in two months; data completeness was 60% and the high-value lanes were blind. I built the spend Pareto — 597 lanes carried 80% of freight spend — pre-validated it with Transportation and Procurement, and took it two levels above my sponsor. I published a 95% valid-ASN gate and held a cohort twice when it failed on a timestamp format. Completeness reached 95%.

TRADE-OFF I MADE. All thousand lanes at once versus spend-weighted cohorts. I chose cohorts and an XML/portal floor so small carriers could stay in the standard; the cost was telling an executive no on lane count.

Failure / learning. Automating dirty data manufactures confident wrong answers; I would publish the gate even earlier, in the kickoff deck.

Three levels deep. L1: I owned the scope analysis and the onboarding standard; engineers built the maps. L2: the lane score was spend × criticality × mode × volume, and no lane owner could contradict the cut. L3: freight spend fell about 10%, roughly $2M in six months, and about 200 lanes followed behind the same gate.

SAFE-SAY. “A thousand lanes were asked; 597 carrying 80% of spend went first — that is spend share, not lane count.” **Source?** “The Elementum program record in the master packet, S9.”

V6 · S13 — Manhattan: Cyber Monday, 4 AM, the scheduler that died

LPs Bias for Action · Customer Obsession · Deliver Results · Dive Deep

20-second version. I was the OMS consultant on allocation and promising for a retailer with 3 DCs and 100 stores. At 4 AM on Cyber Monday the VP called: backorders piling up with inventory present, about $6M of sales at risk against a 95% fill goal. I ranked clears by promise at risk instead of first-in-first-out, rebalanced so no DC drowned, and logged every move. The root cause was an allocation scheduler that died silently at the daylight-saving change. We delivered 99% fill and protected about $8M of peak sales.

TRADE-OFF I MADE. Act before knowing the cause, or wait. I acted, with every rebalance reversible and timestamped.

Failure / learning. Nobody had written a clearing rule for failure — including me. Now the rule is written before the peak.

Three levels deep. L1: I owned the response and the post-mortem mechanisms; engineering fixed the scheduler once I isolated it. L2: the contradiction — available to promise above zero while backorders rose — was my evidence to declare an incident. L3: the heartbeat, DST checklist, 3σ page rule and rehearsed rebalance playbook meant the next peak ran boring.

SAFE-SAY. “About eight million of peak sales protected against about six million at risk — both are the record; any margin figure is my model.” **Source?** “My Manhattan consulting record in the master packet, S13.”

V7 · I1 — independent LLM triage agent: eval first, no citation no proposal

LPs Invent and Simplify · Frugality · Learn and Be Curious · Dive Deep

20-second version. I built an independent LLM triage agent for operational incident queues and treated it as a product, not a demo. The naive version cost $25 per incident and could answer without evidence. I graded historical incidents into an eval set, made it the release gate, required every proposal to cite the ticket and runbook, and routed easy classes to smaller models. Cost fell to $0.40 per incident, 98%, with 100% citation coverage and accuracy held on the eval set.

TRADE-OFF I MADE. One expensive model for everything versus tiered routing. I chose routing, which added complexity and eval maintenance.

Failure / learning. The early eval set grew while I was judging prompts; I would freeze and version the baseline before the first change.

Three levels deep. L1: I built the stack, the eval harness and the operating rule myself. L2: cost by class showed most incidents were easy; small models held on those against the eval set. L3: at FBA scale, access review, data boundaries and drift become programs of their own; I'd keep a human approval gate until production evidence beats the human baseline.

SAFE-SAY. “This was my independent build, not an employer production program.” **Source?** “My build records, captured in the Apple workbook, I1.”

V8 · G1 — Elementum: the UAT that crashed two days before sign-off (my failure)

LPs Are Right, A Lot · Earn Trust · Ownership · Insist on the Highest Standards

20-second version. Two days before UAT sign-off on an Elementum track-and-trace app, five key users had passed all ten end-to-end scenarios. Then the sponsor opened access broadly and concurrent logins crashed the system. My first move made it worse: I reran my scenarios and sent screenshots. I owned the miss to the sponsor, engineering simulated concurrency and fixed it, and I rewrote the UAT contract with numeric load criteria. The sign-off date was missed.

TRADE-OFF I MADE. Hold the sign-off date with a waiver, or miss it honestly. I chose to miss it rather than ask the customer to accept an unproven system.

Failure / learning. My failure was defensive diagnosis — I mistook my coverage for the truth. The first hour of an escalation now goes to reproducing the customer's shape.

Three levels deep. L1: I owned readiness and the criteria. L2: the requirement was implicit — users worked the way their job demanded. L3: the proof the lesson stuck is that my later Flexport launch gate was written in load terms before customer testing.

SAFE-SAY. “Five key users passed ten scenarios, but concurrent access crashed the system two days before sign-off; my criteria omitted load, and the deadline was missed.” **Source?** “Apple workbook G1, pages 43–44.”

V9 · UDC-B4 — Sephora: one promise per customer, in both countries (product lens)

LPs Customer Obsession · Invent and Simplify · Learn and Be Curious · Success and Scale

20-second version. In Utah a store and a dotcom shopper could want the same unit in the same building and get two different answers, because the building kept two books. I treated it as product work: one pool with two selling identities, the requirements ranked so the go-live set was the minimum that made one promise true, and a written list of what we would not build. Two go-lives, zero customer-facing incidents. For Canada, the plan reused an existing cross-dock path, twenty small brands first.

TRADE-OFF I MADE. Fewer features sooner with the deferrals written down — no history conversion, no reserve-math change. The cost landed on analysts, who lived with two systems of record for four months.

Failure / learning. The analyst was a customer I under-served; the interim reporting got a workstream in month three instead of day one.

Three levels deep. L1: I owned the requirement set and the customer outcome. L2: the issues log's own categories — 331 go-live, 77 fast-follow, 36 enhancement — are the record of the triage. L3: 85.4% of 836 issues closed and the rest owned; processing efficiency up 15% by DC Ops' measurement.

SAFE-SAY. “Thirteen percent is the Canada discovery deck's figure for US-managed store volume — the plan at discovery exit, not a measured outcome.” **Source?** “The July 2024 architecture-council deck, the June 2023 Canada discovery deck, and the program issues log.”

V10 · S12 (product-decision facet only) — Flexport FF App: the rebuild-or-reuse rule and partner adoption

LPs Think Big · Frugality · Customer Obsession

20-second version. The hiring manager heard this roadmap. For Venkata, tell only the product decision inside it: I wrote a per-module rule — anything over eight dev-weeks to rebuild gets reused — and chose partners as the first persona. The MVP went live with 11 partners in 10 countries, and 48 of 53 import partners migrated within a month. Operators stayed on old screens two more quarters, and we priced and published that cost.

TRADE-OFF I MADE. Partner-first versus operator-first. I chose partners, knowingly leaving operators on old screens for two more quarters.

Failure / learning. I would have written the reversal trigger into the first draft rather than the second.

Three levels deep. L1: I owned the sequencing recommendation; engineering re-estimated. L2: 20% of the work was still happening in the old app, which made reuse the cheaper path. L3: about $5M of cost avoidance is the record figure — I say it once.

SAFE-SAY. “About five million of cost avoidance — said once, never as an annual run-rate too.” **Source?** “The FF App high-level solution documents and the master packet S12.”

B · STAR answer bank — 16 LPs × 2 real AIQB questions

Each answer runs about 90 seconds aloud. Say the opener, then S, T, A, R in that order, then stop. Answers whose AIQB wording the hiring manager also used are marked in the note line; the story here is different, so it stays fresh.

B1 · Customer Obsession AIQB: Customer Obsession Q1 · story V3 · S14

"Describe a difficult interaction you had with a customer. How did you deal with it? What was the outcome? How would you handle it differently?"

Opener: "The hardest customer conversation I've had was one my own side didn't want to have — telling a customer, two days before their executive review, that our two systems disagreed about $2.5 million of their orders."

S I was a consultant at a Manhattan customer. Two days before an executive review, OMS and WMS did not reconcile — about 200 orders, $2.5M of order value — and a $10M initiative rode on that review. My manager and the room favored a quiet back-end correction.

T I owned the recommendation and, once we chose, the war room.

A I built a discrepancy census by cause on a sample of the 200 so we argued facts first. I told my manager privately, then disagreed on risk: a cross-table script written in two days had no rollback, and an IT audit would turn a data issue into a trust issue. I offered to run the war room myself. I wrote the customer pack — root cause, plan, timeline, no apology-first — and sent it to their IT and finance before the review, not in it. They chose which orders mattered most; we patched those line by line with before-and-after evidence per order.

R The prioritized set reconciled to zero before the review, the handshake got a clean root-cause fix, and the customer awarded the $10M initiative. The reconciliation report became a standing control. Differently: I would have proposed that report before there was a crisis to justify it.

Number to land: about 200 orders, $2.5M of order value; $10M initiative won record · **Do not say:** "we saved $10M" — it is an initiative won, not savings; "the customer was angry" — they were not; they prioritized and gave us time
Likely follow-up: "What if your manager had said no?" — I would have written up the risk assessment and asked for the decision to be recorded with its owner, then committed — with the tripwire named: any audit query on those orders. I would not have run the silent script without that record.

B2 · Customer Obsession AIQB: Customer Obsession Q4 · story V1 · S11

"Give me an example of a time when you asked for customer feedback. How did you use that feedback to drive innovation or improvement? How did the customer respond?"

Opener: "The most useful customer feedback I've had came as a criticism of me: leadership said our visibility product wasn't showing value, and the real customers' feedback was hiding inside our own wave data."

S At Flexport I owned the Shipment Visibility launch across nine teams. Seven pilot customers were on it at $0.66 cost to serve per container; Sales wanted the whole pool boarded at once; leadership said the program was not demonstrating value.

T I had to turn customer experience into evidence that could steer the rollout, and board customers only as fast as the product could serve them well.

A I set a calibration entry bar of about 50 containers per client so each new customer's own data told us whether we were ready for them. I wrote six graduation criteria and published them to Sales before wave one. I froze seven metrics in a weekly review copied from an existing leadership review. In wave three the customer signal said ETA accuracy was off; I traced it to one bad data source and held the wave in public rather than give twenty-plus customers a bad first impression. We fixed the source, then boarded them.

R We went from 7 to 68 customers — 9.7 times — with zero rollbacks, and cost to serve fell from $0.66 to $0.03 per container, about 95%. The customers we held became the cleanest wave. The VP unlocked the full rollout two months early off the review.

Number to land: 7 → 68 customers (9.7×); $0.66 → $0.03, about 95% record · **Do not say:** "ten times"; "I invented the WBR" — I copied a trusted format
Likely follow-up: "How did Sales take the hold?" — They had the six criteria before wave one, so the hold was the rule firing, not my opinion. That is why I publish gates before the first wave — it turns a fight into a check.
Note. The hiring manager heard Shipment Visibility as an operating story; here the angle is the customer signal and the held wave.

B3 · Ownership AIQB: Ownership Q1 · story V4 · S16

"Tell me about a time when you took on something significant outside your area of responsibility. Why was it important? What was the outcome?"

Opener: "I wrote the requirements for a data pipeline no one had asked me to own, because a VP was steering on a number that only I could break."

S At Flexport the Monday review for Shipment Visibility ran on four systems that didn't talk, stitched together in Google Sheets by one person — me. Accuracy was 60%, tickets carried no container ID, and each snapshot took 1.5 to 2 hours.

T Data infrastructure was not my team. Nobody had written requirements for a program's operating metrics. I took the BRD and the cutover; the infra team owned the build.

A I documented the as-is and named the join gap. I priced the status quo at over $100K a year in the infra team's own loaded rates, so they prioritized it themselves instead of me escalating. I froze the scope to the seven metrics already in the review — nothing new. I set acceptance as a parallel run within 1% for consecutive weeks, and I kept running the manual pull every Monday as the rollback so the review never skipped a week. We used a cross-reference table for the ticket join first, then pushed a real key upstream.

R Accuracy went from 60% to 90%, the bus factor went from one to at least two, and the first automated catch was a 4% ticket-sync drop that had been invisible in the manual era.

Number to land: accuracy 60% → 90%; >$100K a year *priced* baseline record · **Do not say:** "we saved $100K" — it was a price on the status quo; "I built the pipeline" — infra built it
Likely follow-up: "What went wrong?" — I didn't plan the data-access security review; it cost two weeks. I told my manager the same day it surfaced and re-sequenced, and we skipped zero review deliveries. Every kickoff now asks whose approval the data needs and how long it takes.

B4 · Ownership AIQB: Ownership Q2 · story V8 · G1

"Describe a time when you didn't think you were going to meet a commitment you promised. How did you identify the risk and communicate it to stakeholders? Is there anything you would do differently?"

Opener: "Two days before a UAT sign-off I had promised, I learned my test plan had missed the one thing that mattered to the customer — and I made it worse before I made it better."

S At Elementum I owned readiness for a customer's track-and-trace application. Five key users had passed all ten end-to-end scenarios; sign-off was two days away.

T Earn the sign-off, including requirements the written scenario list had not made explicit.

A When the sponsor opened access more broadly, concurrent logins crashed the system. My first reaction was wrong: I reran my scenarios, they passed, and I sent screenshots. Then I stopped defending the plan and reproduced the customer's actual shape — many users at once. I told the sponsor plainly that the gap was mine: their users had exposed a performance requirement I failed to surface. Engineering simulated the concurrent load and worked the fix while I rewrote the UAT contract with numeric uptime, page-load and concurrent-load criteria at the customer's user count, data volume and network.

R The sign-off date was missed and confidence had to be rebuilt. What changed permanently is that every critical scenario I own now has numeric entrance and exit criteria, including load at the customer's shape.

Number to land: 5 users × 10 scenarios passed; concurrency crashed it 2 days before sign-off; date missed record · **Do not say:** "the sponsor caused it by opening access" — their users behaved as their work required
Likely follow-up: "How did you communicate it?" — To the sponsor first, as my miss, with what we knew, what we didn't, and when they would hear next. Then to my own leadership with the same words. No screenshots the second time.

B5 · Invent and Simplify AIQB: Invent and Simplify Q3 · story V9 · UDC-B4

"Tell me about a time when you were able to make something simpler for customers. What drove you to implement this change? What was the impact?"

Opener: "At Sephora's Utah DC a store and a dotcom shopper could ask for the same unit in the same building and get two different answers — I made it one answer."

S The building ran as two systemic warehouses — Dotcom and Retail — with duplicate receiving, split storage, internal self-transfers and two planning views.

T I owned the requirement set and the customer outcome: the minimum change that would make one promise true.

A I wrote the customer problem first: one inventory, one promise, two channels — a single location with the Dotcom selling location mapped onto it. I ranked the requirements with one test: does the customer's promise become false without this? Location setup, PO creation with channel reserves, the conversion script and the OMS source node passed. History conversion, reserve-math improvements and a reporting rebuild did not, and went onto a written deferral list. The issues log carried that triage in its own categories — 331 go-live, 77 fast-follow, 36 enhancement.

R Two go-lives with zero customer-facing incidents, and processing efficiency up 15% by DC Ops' own measurement. My miss: analysts lived with two systems of record for four months; the interim reporting deserved a workstream on day one.

Number to land: zero customer-facing incidents across two go-lives; +15% by DC Ops' measurement record · **Do not say:** "nine reserve buckets" — there were three; that it "held to the day" — design was planned for Jul 26 and signed Aug 14
Likely follow-up: "Why not convert history?" — It would have touched every downstream system's past rows for a benefit no shopper would feel. We copied forward only what planning needed — sales history and forecast — and wrote "no conversion of historical transactions" on the scope slide.

B6 · Invent and Simplify AIQB: Invent and Simplify Q5 · story V7 · I1

"Tell me about a time when you had a challenging problem or situation that the usual approach wouldn't address. How did you select an alternative approach? What alternative approach(es) did you consider? What was the end result? What was the impact?"

Opener: "The usual approach to an LLM product is to pick the best model and tune prompts; for an incident-triage agent that gave me good answers at $25 each with no way to check them."

S I independently built a Python/FastAPI triage agent for operational incident queues. The naive version produced useful proposals but cost $25 per incident and could answer without a checkable chain of evidence.

T Make it operations-grade: quality held on known cases, every proposal checkable, unit cost under a dollar — and not present it as an employer deployment.

A I considered three paths: one premium model for everything, prompt tuning alone, or treating it as a product with a quality contract. I chose the contract. I graded historical incidents with known-correct outcomes into an eval set and made it the release gate — every change had to keep the past passing. I added one rule: no citation, no proposal — each action bound to ticket evidence and a runbook line. Then I measured cost by incident class and routed routine classes to smaller models, reserving expensive calls for the hard tail.

R Cost fell from $25 to $0.40 per incident — 98% — with 100% citation coverage and accuracy held on the eval set.

Number to land: $25 → $0.40 per incident, 98%; 100% citations record · **Do not say:** "deployed at my employer"; "zero errors" — the claim is accuracy held on the eval set

Likely follow-up: "What would you do differently?" — My first eval set kept growing while I was judging early prompts, so early comparisons weren't clean. I would freeze and version the baseline before the first experiment.

B7 · Are Right, A Lot AIQB: Are Right, A Lot Q5 · story V8 · G1

"We don't always make the right judgment all the time. Tell me about a time when you made an error in judgment. What was the impact? What did you learn? How have you applied what you learned?"

Opener: "My clearest error in judgment was not the test plan I missed — it was the hour after, when I tried to prove I was right instead of finding out what the customer saw."

S At Elementum, two days before UAT sign-off on a track-and-trace app, five key users had passed all ten scenarios. The sponsor opened access broadly, and users said they could not complete a flow.

T I owned readiness; my job in that moment was to find the truth fast.

A My judgment call was to rerun my scenarios. They passed, and I sent the sponsor screenshots. That was defending my coverage. When it was clear users were still blocked, I reproduced their real shape — many concurrent logins — and the system crashed. I went back to the sponsor and said the gap was mine. Engineering simulated the load and fixed it; I rewrote the readiness criteria in numbers: uptime, page load and concurrent load at the customer's user count, data volume and network.

R The sign-off date was missed and trust had to be rebuilt. I've applied it since: in any escalation, the first hour goes to reproducing the customer's shape, and "works for us" is never readiness evidence.

Number to land: 2 days before sign-off; 5 users × 10 scenarios; date missed record · **Do not say:** a small or blame-shifting failure; "the system was fine, the users were wrong"

Likely follow-up: "How do you know the lesson stuck?" — My next major launch gate at Flexport was written in load terms — a volume of containers in a fixed time at a connectivity threshold — and passed before customers touched it.

B8 · Are Right, A Lot AIQB: Are Right, A Lot Q3 **· story V2 · Crux**

"Tell me about a time when you made a difficult decision with input from many different sources (customers, stakeholders, partner teams, etc.). What was the situation and how did you arrive at your decision? Did the decision turn out to be the correct one? Why or why not?"

Opener: "When Flexport retired an acquired visibility product, the hard part was not the migration — it was deciding, customer segment by segment, who we should keep and who we should honestly let go."

S Crux had 79 customers — $185,892 of ARR and 294,581 containers in 2021 — and the aim was to move them to Shipment Visibility by end 2022. Shipment Visibility did not fit every segment.

T I owned the Shipment Visibility side: which segments our product could serve without new build, and how they would board. The RAPID's recommenders and decider are named in the document. VERIFY my exact RAPID role

A The inputs pulled in different directions. One leader wanted Flexport to be the data authority — everyone on our milestones. Another asked for the cost of keeping two systems. A third wrote that ejecting customers is never a good experience and asked about feature parity and consignee timing. Account owners knew which brokers mattered: one held a national home-improvement retailer's account and was part of a 600-truck drayage company we wanted a relationship with. The decision became one rule per segment: shippers — GKA 2, Enterprise 14, SMB 39 — to Shipment Visibility; forwarders, customs brokers and 3PLs to the SV API with no extra dev, or cancel; two brokers to a partner product; the two competitor SaaS accounts cancelled.

R Every one of the 79 had a decided, dated path. The competitor accounts were cancelled on August 1 and October 24, 2022. I think it was right because no segment was force-fit into a product that didn't serve it.

Number to land: 79 customers; $185,892 ARR; 294,581 containers record-from-docs · **Do not say:** any preserved-ARR or churn number — the document has none

Likely follow-up: "Was cancelling paying customers customer-obsessed?" — Force-fitting a segment we didn't serve would have turned this year's revenue into next year's churn plus support cost. A clean cancel with notice and a path — the API or a partner product — kept it honest.